STIVEN CATALYST

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MANAGEMENT REVIEW

Management without theatre.



ROLE

WHERE THE MANAGER'S WEEK GOES

A foreman's 48 seconds, the weekends and the time alone of 27 CEOs, Drucker's time log, an experiment with quiet time, the two-minute conversation, and a card for logging one week.

48 sec was the average pace of 56 US foremen: 583 activities in one eight-hour shift.

GUEST, 1956 (VIA MINTZBERG, 1975)

INSIDE

COVER STORY
One every 48 seconds
PAGE 03

THE MODEL
Record, prune, consolidate
PAGE 05

TOOL OF THE ISSUE
The one-week time log
PAGE 08

NO. 47 · ROLE

In this issue

Most managers can say where their week should go. Few can say where it went. This issue is about the difference: what the studies of managers' time have found, from the shop floor to the head office, and how to measure your own week before trying to change it.

In 1956, 56 US foremen averaged one activity every 48 seconds. Decades later, 27 CEOs worked on most weekends and spent 28% of their working time alone, mostly in pieces of an hour or less. Peter Drucker's advice from 1967 still stands: record the time, prune it, then consolidate it. An experiment with quiet time was credited with a team of engineers launching on time, and John Kotter shows why some short conversations are not lost time at all.

Stiven Janaqi EDITOR · STIVEN CATALYST

03 COVER STORY
One every 48 seconds

04 THE NUMBERS
Weekends, and time alone

05 THE MODEL
Record, prune, consolidate

06 WHAT THE RESEARCH SAYS
Quiet time, and the two-minute talk

07 HOW IT IS MEASURED
Fifteen-minute blocks

08 TOOL OF THE ISSUE
The one-week time log

09 SOURCES
Sources and method

HOW TO READ THIS ISSUE

Figure
Every figure has its source and year at the foot of its page.

Our reading
Where the editors interpret rather than the research, it says so.

Practice
The steps and the card are proposals to try, not research results.

COVER STORY

One every 48 seconds

In 1975 Henry Mintzberg brought together the studies that had followed managers at work, from foremen to company presidents, in the United States, Canada, Sweden and Britain. On the shop floor and at the top, the pace was the same: unrelenting.

583
activities in one eight-hour shift, for 56 US foremen (Guest, 1956)

30 min
without interruption only about once every two days, for 160 British managers (Stewart, 1967)

93%
of the meetings and calls of Mintzberg's five chief executives were arranged ad hoc

His chief executives started only 32% of their own contacts. Yet the effective ones still steered their time, Mintzberg found: they used their obligations for their own ends, and turned what they wanted to do into obligations, a project others had to report on, a visit announced in public.

“Free time is made, not found.”

OUR READING

A week is rarely lost in the large blocks on the calendar. It goes in the small pieces between them.

Source: Henry Mintzberg, Harvard Business Review, 1975

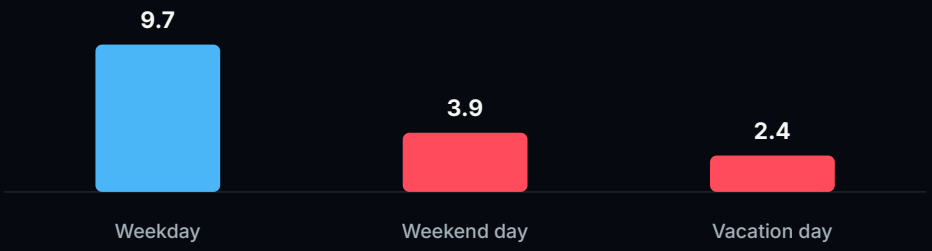
Old studies, each with its year: Guest observed one shift per foreman, Stewart's managers kept diaries, Mintzberg observed five chief executives for a week each. All figures as Mintzberg reports them.

THE NUMBERS

Weekends, and time alone

Michael Porter and Nitin Nohria had the assistants of 27 CEOs of large companies code their time in 15-minute blocks, around the clock, for a quarter each, and check it with the CEO. Beyond the 62.5-hour week, the data show when the work happened and how much of it was the CEO's own.

AVERAGE HOURS OF WORK PER DAY, 27 CEOS



79%
of weekend days included work

70%
of vacation days included work

28%
of working time alone; 59% of it in blocks of an hour or less, 18% in blocks of two hours or more

OUR READING

The scarce resource is not hours. It is hours in one piece.

Source: Michael E. Porter & Nitin Nohria, Harvard Business Review, 2018

Time alone ranged from 10% to 48% between CEOs. The article does not say whether the weekend and vacation averages count only the days with work. Large, mostly public companies; the study began in 2006.

THE MODEL

Record, prune, consolidate

In The Effective Executive (1967), Peter Drucker writes that effective executives do not start with their tasks; they start with their time, and first find out where it actually goes. He sets out three steps.

01
Record
Write down where the time goes as it happens, not afterwards from memory.

02
Prune
Cut what brings nothing; hand over what others can do.

03
Consolidate
Gather the time you control into the largest possible blocks.

Three questions for the log

1. What would happen if this were not done at all?
2. Which of these could someone else do just as well, if not better?
3. What do I do that wastes your time? This one is for the team.

OUR READING

The log comes first because memory flatters. It remembers the week we planned, not the one we had.

Source: Peter F. Drucker, Harper & Row, 1967 (via Psychology Today, 2022)

The steps and questions follow Drucker; we did not see the book itself and confirmed them in independent summaries. The reading is the editors'.

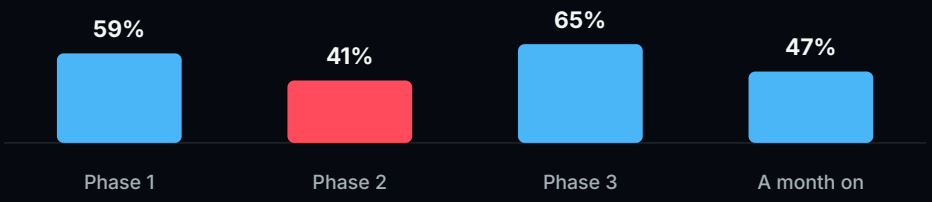
More in the essay The Operations Manager I want to be

WHAT THE RESEARCH SAYS

Quiet time, and the two-minute talk

Leslie Perlow spent nine months with software engineers under deadline. Of their exchanges with colleagues, they judged 96% helpful but only 10% urgent. So she set quiet time: three mornings a week without interruptions (phases 1 and 3), and a phase with fixed hours for talking (phase 2).

ENGINEERS RATING THEIR PRODUCTIVITY ABOVE AVERAGE



The vice president credited the experiment with the product's on-time launch, the second in the division's history. Nine months after it ended, little was left, yet even two years on, managers checked up on the engineers less often. John Kotter's study of 15 general managers (1976–1981) adds the other side: a two-minute talk in the corridor can do the work of a 15–30 minute meeting, when the manager has a clear agenda and a network of relationships.

OUR READING

Not every interruption is waste. The ones to move are those that could have waited.

Sources: Leslie A. Perlow, Administrative Science Quarterly, 1999 (via interruptions.net, full text); John P. Kotter, Harvard Business Review, 1982

One team, self-ratings on a 1–5 scale, no control group. The phase-2 mornings were quiet by default too.

HOW IT IS MEASURED

Fifteen-minute blocks

Oriana Bandiera and colleagues also cut the week of 1,114 manufacturing CEOs in six countries, Germany among them, into 15-minute blocks. Each morning they asked for the day's plan, each evening for what had happened: 50 hours a week on average.

1. **Log as it happens**
   In 15-minute blocks, from the first call to the last email.
2. **Fix the categories first**
   Planned or not, alone or with whom, and on what.
3. **Compare morning and evening**
   What was planned, what was done, what took its place.
4. **Count the blocks in one piece**
   An hour or more alone, without interruption.

Definitions decide the result. In Bandiera's study, emergencies took 4% of CEO time and just under 10% of planned activities were cancelled; Porter and Nohria counted 36% of time as reacting to unfolding issues. The questions were different.

HYPOTHETICAL EXAMPLE, A SHIFT MANAGER'S WEEK

Logged	47 hours, 188 blocks
Unplanned	71 blocks, 52 of which could have waited
In one piece	two blocks of an hour alone

The 52 blocks that could have waited are next week's quiet morning. The numbers are invented.

Sources: Oriana Bandiera, Andrea Prat, Stephen Hansen & Raffaella Sadun, Journal of Political Economy, 2020 (via LSE Research Online, accepted manuscript); Michael E. Porter & Nitin Nohria, Harvard Business Review, 2018; Peter F. Drucker, Harper & Row, 1967 (via Psychology Today, 2022)

Bandiera collected one week per CEO, by phone with the CEO or an assistant. Steps and example are the editors'.

TOOL OF THE ISSUE

The one-week time log

One card a day, for one ordinary week. Write as you go, not in the evening. On Friday, add up the blocks by category and sort them with the Pareto tool: start with the two or three that take the most time.

01 This morning's plan the three things that must happen today

02 The log 15-minute blocks: what, with whom, planned or not

03 In one piece blocks of an hour or more alone, without interruption

04 Could have waited interruptions that were not urgent: who, about what

05 Drop or hand over what would happen if it were not done; who else could do it

06 Next week's block one protected block: day, hours, purpose, who knows about it

Sources: Peter F. Drucker, Harper & Row, 1967 (via Psychology Today, 2022); Michael E. Porter & Nitin Nohria, Harvard Business Review, 2018; Leslie A. Perlow, Administrative Science Quarterly, 1999 (via interruptions.net, full text)

A practice proposed by the editors, after Drucker's three steps, the 15-minute blocks of the CEO studies and Perlow's quiet time.

Open the tool: Pareto 80/20 stivencatalyst.com/tools/pareto/

SOURCES AND METHOD

Every figure has a source.

The figures in this issue come from the sources below. The year shows how recent each one is.

The Manager's Job: Folklore and Fact
Henry Mintzberg, Harvard Business Review, 1975
https://hbr.org/1990/03/the-managers-job-folklore-and-fact

How CEOs Manage Time
Michael E. Porter & Nitin Nohria, Harvard Business Review, 2018
https://hbr.org/2018/07/how-ceos-manage-time

The Effective Executive
Peter F. Drucker, Harper & Row, 1967 · via Psychology Today, 2022

The Time Famine: Toward a Sociology of Work Time
Leslie A. Perlow, Administrative Science Quarterly, 1999 · via interruptions.net, full text
https://doi.org/10.2307/2667031

What Effective General Managers Really Do
John P. Kotter, Harvard Business Review, 1982
https://hbr.org/1999/03/what-effective-general-managers-really-do

CEO Behavior and Firm Performance
Oriana Bandiera, Andrea Prat, Stephen Hansen & Raffaella Sadun, Journal of Political Economy, 2020 · via LSE Research Online, accepted manuscript
https://doi.org/10.1086/705331

CORRECTION · 14 OCTOBER 2026

The cover now credits the 48-second figure to Guest (1956) via Mintzberg (1975). The 48 seconds is how Mintzberg summed up Guest's study of 56 foremen; the cover first named only Guest.

EDITORIAL METHOD

Each figure was checked for its year, its publisher and what exactly it measures. Where the publisher's page could not be opened, the figure was checked against independent summaries and is marked “via”. The editors' interpretation is marked “Our reading”. Figures that could not be confirmed are not in the issue.



MANAGEMENT REVIEW

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Every issue, one management question, checked against the best research.

ALL ISSUES

stivencatalyst.com/magazine/management-review.html

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